



Focus on youth: (L-R) The Hindu CEO L. V. Navaneeth moderates an engrossing discussion on the significance of youth sports development as Aditya Madan (Public Policy Consultant to Punjab Education Minister), Ranjit Bajaj (Director, Minerva Punjab FC), and Anandh Kumar (Special Secretary, Sports, Punjab) watch on. R. V. MOORTHY

Harnessing youth sports for skill building

Youth sports development should begin with setting up a safe environment and the required infrastructure at the grassroots level, said Ranjit Bajaj, Director, Punjab FC, during a panel discussion on 'Harnessing Youth Sports for Skill Building' during the Sportstar 'Focus Punjab' Sports Conclave in Chandigarh.

"With sports, it's never overnight magic. You plant the seeds, take care of the plant, and the deserved fruits will follow," he said. Speaking about the exposure the young athletes get by playing at a global level, he said, "We keep talking of exposure, friendlies, and tours; all those are for experienced athletes, to improve 0.0001%. If you give the same exposure to youth, their development is 20-30%."

"Ninety per cent of all sports is in the mind. Unless your mind believes, no matter what you do, you cannot do it."

Aditya Madan, Policy Consultant to the Punjab Education Minister, explained that all levels of the pyramid were catered to during the formulation of the Punjab Government's policy.

"Punjab was coming up with one after many years. We wanted it to be comprehensive and had to ensure it caters to ground reality," he said.

"For the Sports Policy, we had a public consultation where people from around the country and even the

diaspora sent in suggestions. It makes me really happy that we could reach out to people and get their responses," he added.

Anand Kumar, Special Secretary, Sports, Punjab, also spoke at length about the formulation of these policies. "We thought the sports policy should not be just for the sake of it. We have touched upon all issues, whether it is related to a current sportsperson, an injury, a retired athlete, the diet, or even award money," he said.

"We wanted to inculcate our road map for the next 5-6 years. It will take a gestation period of 4-5 years, keeping everything in mind. 2024 is a crucial year because whatever is spelled out in the policy is going to be implemented on the ground," he added.

Bajaj, who was one of the stakeholders involved in the newly-framed sports policy, was also bullish about the positive effects, including the reservation of posts or creation of jobs for athletes. "Sportspeople have always been looking for security. Now there are avenues with jobs," he said.

"Haryana has done well not because their genes are better than us; it's because their policies are better than us. That's all we needed to change. Now our policy is comparable to theirs, and you will see a revival of sports in Punjab," he added.